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Shell We Talk?

When I was growing up I spent a lot of time outside, during that time I saw a lot of large snails, maybe up to an inch and a half. But every snail I've seen is dwarfed by the Giant African Land Snail. The Giant African Snail, or *Lissachatina fulica* (*Achatina fulica*) is part of the class Gastropoda, and considered to be the largest terrestrial or land snail in the world. This species of snail has a large variety in size, an average adult is between 3-4 inches, but the largest of them can get up to a whole 8 inches (London Zoo). Before this I didn't really know anything about this snail, I chose purely based on the name. Since then I've learned a lot about this both amazing and harmful animal and I hope to tell you a little about it as well.



WK Cheng, *Giant African Snail found in Hong Kong being measured*

As seen in the picture these snails have some of the largest shells of all land invertebrates only matched by others of its genus. Along with the shell we can see that it has a soft body that goes inside the shell. If we flip it over we would be able to see its one muscular foot and the radula, and taking all this into account we can tell that it is a mollusk. Although a little bit hard to see, we can tell that the picture was taken in a more tropical and humid environment, matching the snail's environment. The snail lives in a large number of countries across the globe, but all of them have tropical climates and high humidity in common (Venette and Larson 1).

Giant African Snails are known to eat all kinds of different plants, fruits, vegetables, and even bark (Michigan Invasive Species). But that is where the problem is, the snails as the name suggests are native to Africa, specifically the coastal east side of Africa. However today they are found across the entire Tropical Zone and considered highly invasive and damaging, to the point where they are included in the ISSG's "100 of the World's Worst Invasive Alien Species". They have spread far and wide, largely due to their high reproductive rate. They are hermaphrodites and can lay up to 1200 eggs a year, and taking their 6 month maturity over their 5-7 year lifespan a single snail can produce up to 7,800 eggs in its life (London Zoo). Thanks to this high reproductive rate the species is highly invasive and not endangered.



Hubert Szczygieł, *Giant African Snail on Bamboo in Hawaii*

Through human transport, whether intentional or not, they have spread far throughout the Tropical Zone, from Hawaii to Brazil and South East Asia. Due to the fact that they “are known to consume over 500 species of plants” they pose serious food and environmental risks (USGS). And they don’t just endanger our environment and our food but us directly as well. “*Lissachatina fulica* can carry at least 36 pathogen species, including two-thirds that can infect humans”

(Gippet). Of these the most common are members of the *Angiostrongylus* family, specifically *Angiostrongylus cantonensis*, a parasite which can cause eosinophilic meningitis (Gippet).

Luckily outside of Hawaii the US has been able to mostly keep the snail out of the wild. However other places aren't as lucky, in Brazil “*Achatina fulica* is now widespread in at least 23 out of 26 Brazilian states” (Thiengo), and causing large amounts of environmental damage.

Although this is an amazing creature we need to know the risks and dangers it poses to us and our environment. Its high reproduction rate, ability to eat many plants, and the diseases it carries make it harmful to the environment and we should be watchful and prepared for it.

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